In the coming days, the Indian military high command would take decisions that lacked even the most basic common sense. Even as Palit was coming out of the defence minister's room with Nehru's 'the military must decide where to fight' mandate, Bogey Sen had decided to sack Niranjan Prasad as GOC 4 Division. Less than three hours previously, as he was leaving Tawang, Sen had eventually endorsed Prasad's decision to pull back from Bum-la and evacuate Tawang. Surely, having seen for himself the effect of the headlong retreat from Zimithang on Prasad and other senior officers, Sen was experienced enough to know that to pull back any further would result in losing not just all the supplies and material that had so painstakingly been put together, but a withdrawal without a fight would further sap the morale of the men and officers. So far, after the first couple of hours of fighting on the Nam Ka Chu, Tsangdhar, Khenzemane, and Bum-la, all Indian units that had come into contact with the Chinese were only fighting in penny packets or withdrawing. Had it been decided that Tawang was to be held at all costs, it would have made perfect sense to replace Prasad as the GOC since the army commander felt he had lost the will to fight. But to institute this change after the withdrawal order was given was to add considerably to the existing chaos.

On the evening of 23 October neither Delhi, Lucknow nor Tezpur had any idea where the next defensive line was supposed to be; the only orders given until then were to abandon Tawang and Bum-la and fall back on Jang. When Palit took the draft of the order to hold Se-la to the chief, it was decided that Thapar, Palit and the IB chief, Mullik, would fly immediately to Tezpur and discuss the matter with Bogey Sen in person. From all indications, Thapar was still not fully convinced about the decision to hold Se-la. On his own initiative, Palit put into place steps for the stocking of supplies for Se-la, working on the assumption that five battalions would be required to hold the feature.

As they flew to Tezpur, it seemed Thapar had made up his mind to finally ask Kaul, still confined to his sickbed, to relinquish command of IV Corps. Lieutenant General Harbaksh Singh, who had been Bogey Sen's deputy in 161 Brigade in 1948, was to be appointed in his place the next day. Niranjan Prasad's simultaneous exit would mean a complete overhaul at the top, which would leave Sen as the most experienced of the lot. On landing at Tezpur, the three officers made a beeline for the Ops Room where Sen conducted a briefing. It was soon obvious to all present that the